

MHM Basics: A Detailed Guide to Menstrual Health

Understanding your menstrual cycle is essential for self-care, symptom tracking, and overall reproductive wellness. This guide explains the phases of the cycle, common symptoms, and practical support strategies to help you manage each stage with confidence.

1. What is Menstrual Health?

Menstrual health refers to the physical, mental, and social well-being of people who experience a menstrual cycle. It includes the ability to manage menstruation hygienically and without stigma, and to understand how cycle changes may affect daily life.

Why it matters:

Consistent cycle awareness helps identify normal patterns, anticipate symptoms, and know when a healthcare provider should be consulted. It also empowers you to make better choices about nutrition, activity, and emotional care throughout the month.

2. Phases of the Menstrual Cycle

Menstrual phase (Day 1–5):

- Bleeding begins as the uterine lining sheds.
- Estrogen and progesterone levels are low.
- Common symptoms include cramps, fatigue, bloating, headaches, and mood changes.
- Support this phase with hydration, gentle movement, rest, and iron-rich foods.

Follicular phase (Day 6–14):

- The body produces more estrogen and the uterine lining starts to thicken again.
- The follicle in the ovary matures and prepares to release an egg.
- Energy often improves and mood may become more positive.
- Focus on balanced meals, light exercise, and consistent sleep.

Ovulation (Around Day 14):

- A mature egg is released from the ovary and fertility is highest.
- Body temperature may rise slightly and cervical mucus may become clearer.
- Some people experience mild pelvic discomfort or breast tenderness.
- Stay hydrated, reduce stress, and support your body with nutrient-dense foods.

Luteal phase (Day 15–28):

- Progesterone rises to prepare the uterus for a possible pregnancy.
- If pregnancy does not occur, progesterone drops and the cycle returns to menstruation.
- Symptoms may include bloating, breast tenderness, mood swings, irritability, and cravings.
- Support this phase with gentle exercise, magnesium-rich foods, and emotional self-care.

3. Tracking Your Cycle

Cycle tracking helps you notice changes and plan for the days when symptoms are most pronounced. Recording details over several cycles gives you a clearer picture of what is normal and what may need medical attention.

Tracking checklist:

- First day of bleeding and flow intensity.
- Duration of the period and whether it is heavier or lighter than usual.
- Pain levels for cramps, back pain, and headaches.
- Emotional symptoms such as mood swings, anxiety, or irritability.
- Energy levels, appetite changes, and sleep quality.
- Fertility signs like basal body temperature and cervical mucus consistency.

4. Self-Care and Symptom Management

Nutrition

- Eat whole foods, lean proteins, and plenty of fruits and vegetables.
- Choose complex carbohydrates for sustained energy and fiber to support digestion.
- Reduce caffeine, salt, and processed sugar, especially before menstruation.

Physical activity

- Gentle movement like walking, yoga, or stretching can relieve cramps.
- During higher-energy phases, consider moderate exercise such as swimming or cycling.
- Listen to your body and rest when needed, especially during the menstrual phase.

Emotional care

- Practice mindfulness, journaling, or breathing exercises to manage mood changes.
- Stay connected with supportive friends, family, or groups.
- Set realistic expectations and allow yourself extra rest when emotions feel intense.

5. When to Seek Medical Help

- Severe or disabling pain that interferes with daily life.
- Heavy bleeding that soaks through pads or tampons every hour for several hours.
- Irregular cycles, missed periods, or sudden changes in bleeding patterns.
- Unusual discharge, strong odor, or pelvic pain that persists.
- Symptoms that worsen over time or remain severe for more than a few months.

6. Helpful Resources

- Track your cycle for at least three months to understand your personal pattern.
- Keep notes on symptoms and lifestyle factors so you can share them with your healthcare provider.
- Use trusted health resources and educational materials to learn more about menstrual health.
- Remember that every body is different; what works for one person may not work for another.